

Research Statement

Qilin Zhang

I am a macroeconomist who studies topics in public and family economics. I use microdata and quantitative models to study how households respond to institutions and public policy. China is the main setting for my research because its demographic and institutional changes raise direct questions about family decisions, public investment, and long-run economic outcomes. My current work focuses on marriage, parental investment, and the allocation of resources across generations. I also study local government debt and public finance.

My job market paper, “Gender-biased Dynastic Savings and the Marriage Market: Evidence from China,” studies how parents’ investments in their children shape the marriage market in China. I combine household survey data with a quantitative model in which parents allocate resources between education and the financial assets their children bring into marriage. Gender differences in education technology and the expectation that husbands bring assets to marriage shape this allocation. I use the model to examine how rising parental resources and transfers affect marriage outcomes.

Marriage, parental investment, and household decisions

Using data from the China Family Panel Studies, I document three patterns that discipline the model. Marriage is assortative in education, and highly educated women are more likely to remain single. Education spending responds more strongly to parental income for daughters than for sons. Parents of sons save more for their children’s marriage. These patterns motivate a model that links parents’ allocation between education and financial assets to their children’s marriage prospects.

In the model, each family has one child. Altruistic parents allocate resources among their own consumption, education spending, and an asset transfer to the child. Education spending raises the probability of attaining high education through a gender-specific technology. Children enter a transferable-utility marriage market with different education and asset levels and idiosyncratic preferences. The marriage surplus depends on education matching, asset pooling, and a norm that penalizes husbands whose premarital assets fall short of their wives’. Parents anticipate marriage-market returns when choosing their investments.

I use the model to study policy counterfactuals. Equalizing education technology across genders raises the marriage rate by 0.62 percentage points. As parents grow richer with China’s growth, the model accounts for 35 percent of the proportional fall in the crude marriage rate between 2010 and 2024 and predicts a further decline. The effects of transfers also depend on their recipients: subsidies to newlyweds raise marriage, whereas equal-sized transfers to parents lower it. These results show how policies that change investment costs or household resources can affect marriage decisions and the distribution of investment across children and families.

The project links parental investment to marriage matching through the education and assets children bring into the market. The counterfactuals are one-step experiments: parents optimize against baseline marriage-market continuation values, and I then re-solve matching under the resulting changes in education and asset composition, holding the sex ratio fixed. They quantify the response to these changes without simulating successive cohorts or imposing a fixed point between parental investment and the next generation’s marriage market.

Public finance and local government debt

My second project is a solo-authored paper, “A Micro Anatomy of the Hidden Local Government Debt in China: 2014–2023,” presented at the 2025 Southern Economic Association Annual Meeting. The paper introduces a newly constructed dataset containing firm-level and city-level information on 2,940 industrial local government financing vehicles across 305 cities, compiled from public disclosures. The project is motivated

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by a basic public finance question: when formal fiscal resources are limited, how do local governments finance investment, and what are the consequences for the allocation of resources? The paper documents heterogeneity in hidden debt exposure across regions and sectors. It places local government debt in an institutional setting in which local governments have important responsibilities for investment and development but face constraints on ordinary-budget revenue. The dataset supports future work on the geography of off-balance-sheet debt, fiscal transparency, and debt sustainability.

Ongoing and future research

In “Mass Layoffs and Fertility: Evidence from WARN-Based Shocks,” joint with Yuchen Zhu, I study how local labor-market shocks affect fertility. Using WARN mass-layoff notices linked to county-level natality data from 2020 to 2024, we examine how the timing and intensity of layoffs relate to subsequent fertility. Preliminary results suggest that larger layoff shocks are followed by higher fertility, with the response emerging about ten months after the shock and concentrated among large layoffs. Ongoing work examines the roles of the opportunity cost of time and maternal selection. In “Residential Mobility and Household Consumption,” joint with Yanqi Li, I study the relationship between residential mobility and household consumption using PSID data. Looking ahead, I am interested in how retirement expectations and intergenerational transfers shape saving and education investment, and in how regional fiscal conditions affect the cost and availability of education, housing, and family services.

Across these projects, I begin with detailed microdata and use quantitative models when they help distinguish mechanisms or evaluate policy counterfactuals. I am interested in questions that matter both for academic research and for the decisions faced by households and policymakers.